

LIGHTING UNLIMITED × SHOPIFY

A self-serve B2B storefront — without leaving DDI behind

A branded, login-gated ordering portal where your contractors and accounts log in, see their own pricing, and place orders on their own — so counter sales scale without the phone calls and paper tickets.

Shopify Plus · B2B portal · DDI-integrated · 4 Arizona branches

OVERVIEW

Where Shopify fits

Lighting Unlimited is a lighting & electrical distributor serving the greater Phoenix Valley from four branches, with roughly 92% of sales B2B. The opportunity isn't a new sales team — it's giving the customers you already serve a faster way to buy.

The problem today

Nearly every order runs through a person — walk-ins, phone calls, and manually written tickets on a pre-coded pricing matrix. It works, but as the company scales, the overhead to handle all those manual transactions gets heavy. There's no online interface for the customers who just want to log in and re-order at their agreed pricing.

The goal

A branded, gated storefront (e.g. an LU-owned domain "powered by Shopify") where account customers log in to their own tier pricing and self-serve — while **DDI stays your source of truth** and the big, complex spec jobs stay exactly where they are.

Guardrail we'll respect: manufacturers (Acuity, Philips, Lutron, Minka, etc.) restrict public online listing. Everything sits **behind a login on your own branded site** — not on a public marketplace — which keeps you inside your buying-group and channel agreements.

CURRENT STATE

How it works right now

A quick map of today's stack and the three ways customers buy — so we only rebuild what's worth rebuilding.

Systems today

- **ERP:** DDI (distributor ERP) — stays the system of record; you may evaluate NetSuite down the line
- **E-commerce:** none currently (previous site retired); manual listings on Amazon & eBay, low volume
- **Payments:** a separate card processor (buying-group negotiated rates); most sales are on terms / AR
- **Buying group:** Affiliated Distributors — channel & pricing agreements to preserve

Three ways customers buy

- **Counter & pop-up pricing** — walk-in / phone, pre-coded tier pricing. ← **the best fit to move online**
- **Outside sales / spec jobs** — complex quotes, large POs (e.g. \$100k retrofits). Stays in DDI
- **Municipal / contract** — blanket POs & pre-negotiated annual pricing; one city requires an online PO portal

Pricing complexity

Tiers today are bronze / silver / gold, moving toward a cleaner bronze / silver / gold / platinum model — with customer-category modifiers (electrician vs. general contractor vs. property management). Net terms (net 30 / 45 / 60) are common. This tier count is the main thing that decides the plan (below).

USE CASES

What we'd build on Shopify

Straight from our conversation — mapped to Shopify B2B capabilities. Core = we'll validate feasibility in the technical discovery.

Self-serve ordering

CORE

Account customers log in and place their own orders at their agreed pricing — no phone call or counter visit required.

Login-gated catalog

CORE

Products visible only after login on your branded site — protects manufacturer channel rules and buying-group agreements.

Customer-specific pricing & tiers

CORE

Catalogs & price lists per company/tier (bronze→platinum) plus category modifiers, driven by who's logged in.

B2B payment terms

CORE

Net 30 / 45 / 60 and pay-on-account, so online ordering matches how your customers already pay.

Municipal / contract portal

CORE

Upload pre-negotiated blanket pricing — covers the city that requires an online portal to cut POs.

DDI integration

CORE

Orders & fulfillment sync with DDI; outside-sales quotes handled as draft orders; complex jobs stay in DDI.

Payments & Shop Pay

COMPARE

Shopify Payments unlocks Shop Pay; or keep an approved third-party processor (+~0.2% on Plus). We'll compare vs. your buying-group rate.

In-store POS

OPTIONAL

Unify counter sales across the four branches on Shopify POS later — weighed against your current processor's value.

Explicitly out of scope for now: the large, complex spec/quote jobs and \$100k POs — those stay in DDI. Shopify targets the repeatable counter & account ordering that eats the most manual time.

PLANS & PRICING

Shopify Plus

Your model — four pricing tiers with category modifiers, net payment terms, municipal contract pricing and a login-gated catalog — needs the full B2B suite. That points to **one plan: Shopify Plus**. The core plans cap catalogs and price lists and can't handle this pricing structure.

YOUR PLAN

Shopify Plus

\$2,300 /mo base

At ~\$20M B2B revenue you're above the ~\$7.9M threshold, so billing runs on the Variable Platform Fee — **~\$3,000/mo effective** (see below). Full B2B suite, built for your pricing model.

- **Unlimited** companies, customer catalogs & price lists
- **Tiered pricing** — bronze / silver / gold / platinum + category modifiers
- **Net payment terms** (net 30/45/60) & pay-on-account
- Login-gated B2B storefront + wholesale & D2C on one store
- Municipal / contract catalogs with pre-negotiated pricing
- Draft orders, checkout customization, expansion stores

Payments

Shopify Payments — standard cards	2.25% + 30¢
Shopify Payments — Amex	2.95% + 30¢
Approved third-party processor (keep yours)	+ ~0.2% on Plus

Platform cost at your volume

You pay the **higher of** the \$2,300/mo base or the Variable Platform Fee (VPF). At **~\$20M in revenue** you're above the ~\$7.9M threshold, so VPF applies — and it's charged by channel. Because you're **~92% B2B**, the rate that matters is the lowest one:

B2B — your primary channel	0.18%
Retail (POS)	0.25%
D2C (online)	0.35%
Effective platform cost — B2B 0.18% × ~\$20M	≈ \$36,000/yr (~\$3,000/mo)

Effective platform cost based on ~\$20M annual revenue at the B2B VPF rate (0.18%); final figure moves with your actual revenue and channel mix. Card rates are standard published rates, confirmed at underwriting; incentives confirmed on the order form.

NEXT STEPS

What it actually takes to go live by January 1

A ~16-week runway from mid-September. It's achievable — but tight through the holidays — so the sequence matters. The **DDI integration is the critical path**; everything else runs alongside it. Owners are noted on each step.

● Sept 15 · Solo Media intro

Partner intro. Meet Solo Media Group and kick off scoping — the DDI integration (does it expose an open API?), the pricing-tier model, catalog gating rules and data migration. *Solo Media · you · Shopify SE.*

● Sept 16 · demo

See it live. Walk the B2B portal — login-gated catalogs, tier pricing, self-serve ordering. **TCO & pricing shared at the end of the demo call.** *Shopify · you.*

● After the demo → Sept 30

Contract sent after the demo → sign by Sept 30. The Plus agreement goes out right after the demo; signing by the 30th locks the incentive. **Partner scoping runs in tandem** so no time is lost on the paperwork. *You (sign) · Solo Media (scope).*

● Oct 1 · build begins

Kickoff & foundations. Stand up the Plus store, environments and access; lock the DDI integration architecture (native connector vs. middleware vs. custom on the open API). *Solo Media · Harrison.*

● October · DDI integration

The long pole. Build the connection so the storefront shows **real-time stock & availability** on login and orders flow back into DDI as your source of truth. *Solo Media · Harrison.*

● Oct – Nov · B2B build

The portal itself. Company accounts + **login-gated catalogs** (respecting manufacturer rules), **per-customer / tier pricing** (bronze→platinum + category modifiers), **net terms**, and the storefront/theme. *Solo Media.*

● November · data migration

Load the catalog. Products, images and pricing rules imported; your customer/account list mapped to the correct tiers; manufacturer-gated brands hidden until login. *Solo Media · Harrison (data).*

● Late Nov – mid Dec · UAT

Test everything that matters. Stock accuracy, order-to-DDI flow, per-account pricing, login gating, net-terms checkout, and the municipal PO portal (if in v1). Fix and re-test. *You · Solo Media · Shopify SE.*

● Mid – late Dec · launch prep

Final data sync, content, train your team, staging sign-off, and the go-live checklist (domain, payments, redirects). *All.*

● January 1 · go-live

Launch on Shopify Plus — the self-serve, login-gated B2B portal live for your accounts.

What we need from you to hit Jan 1

- **Partner decision** — confirm Solo Media Group as your implementation partner
- **Confirm the phases** — agree how the build is staged
- **What's included in Phase 1** — lock the v1 scope (what goes live Jan 1 vs. what follows)
- **Sign on to Shopify by end of September**

Honest read: Jan 1 is ~16 weeks including the holidays — doable, but the **DDI integration and an end-of-September signature** are what make or break it. If DDI turns out heavier than scoped, we protect the date by phasing — launch the core portal Jan 1 and add the municipal portal / POS right after.

Prepared by Nicole DeGennaro · Shopify — for Lighting Unlimited. Built from our intro call. B2B feasibility confirmed in technical discovery; pricing & scope finalized with an implementation partner.